

About Validation Source Reliability Standard

Governing Whether the Sources Behind Validation Evidence Can Be Relied Upon

Evidence has an origin.

Someone observed it.

Something measured it.

A system generated it.

A repository stored it.

A process transformed it.

An organization supplied it.

A model may have interpreted it.

And every one of those relationships can affect validation.

Validation Source Reliability Standard (VSRS) is the sixth Parent Standard of **VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture**, governing whether the sources behind Validation Evidence can be sufficiently identified, traced, assessed, bounded, and relied upon for the validation roles assigned to them.

VSRS addresses one fundamental question:

Can the source behind Validation Evidence be sufficiently relied upon for the role that evidence is expected to perform?

Why Validation Source Reliability Standard Exists

Validation may use evidence that appears convincing while the source conditions behind that evidence remain unclear.

A source may be:

- unidentified,
- incorrectly attributed,
- dependent upon another source,
- operating outside its competence,
- financially interested in the result,
- methodologically dependent,
- based upon outdated information,
- separated from the original evidence by multiple intermediaries,
- or unable to demonstrate how the evidence was produced.

None of these conditions automatically proves that the evidence is false.

But each can materially affect how much validation confidence the evidence should support.

VSRS exists to make those source conditions governable.

Evidence Fitness Is Not Source Reliability

VALIDOS® deliberately separates two questions.

Validation Evidence Fitness Standard asks:

Is the evidence fit for the validation question?

Validation Source Reliability Standard asks:

Can the source behind that evidence be sufficiently relied upon?

This separation is essential.

Evidence may be highly relevant, applicable, well-covered, and adequate while originating from a source whose reliability remains uncertain.

Likewise, an extremely reliable institution may provide evidence that is irrelevant to the Validation Criterion being examined.

Therefore:

Fit Evidence ≠ Reliable Source

and:

Reliable Source ≠ Fit Evidence

Both conditions must be governed independently.

Source Before Execution

VALIDOS® establishes the architectural progression:

**Validation Object → Validation Purpose & Scope → Validation Criteria
→ Validation Method → Validation Evidence Fitness → Validation
Source Reliability → Validation Execution**

Before the architecture asks whether validation was correctly executed, it establishes:

- what is being validated,
 - why it is being validated,
 - against what criteria,
 - through which methodology,
-

- whether the evidence is fit,
- and whether the sources behind that evidence are sufficiently reliable.

This creates a stronger basis for execution governance.

What Is a Validation Source?

A Validation Source is not limited to a person or publication.

It may include:

- an individual,
- organization,
- laboratory,
- institution,
- database,
- dataset origin,
- sensor,
- measuring instrument,
- AI model,
- operational system,
- software process,
- repository,
- document origin,
- monitoring system,
- external provider,
- or another entity capable of generating, recording, transmitting, transforming, interpreting, maintaining, or supplying Validation Evidence.

The relevant question is not simply:

Who supplied the evidence?

It is:

Which source relationships materially contributed to the evidence upon which validation depends?

Source Identity Before Source Trust

A source cannot be meaningfully assessed if its identity is unclear.

VSRS therefore begins with source identification and attribution.

Depending upon the validation context, it may be necessary to know:

- the organization,
- system,
- instrument,
- individual,
- model,

- repository,
- version,
- dataset origin,
- or another source representation.

The required level of identity precision depends upon the validation role and consequence.

Attribution Matters

Evidence may be attributed directly to its origin.

But evidence may also arrive through:

- reports,
- databases,
- publications,
- aggregators,
- intermediaries,
- AI-generated summaries,
- analytical systems,
- or derived datasets.

VSRS distinguishes the entity presenting evidence from the entity that originally generated the underlying information.

This prevents downstream presentation from being confused with upstream origin.

Provenance Creates Context

Validation becomes stronger when the pathway through which evidence reached the validation process can be reconstructed.

That pathway may include:

Origin → Generation → Recording → Transformation → Transmission → Aggregation → Storage → Retrieval → Validation Use

Not every validation requires forensic reconstruction of every step.

The required provenance depth should remain proportionate to the Validation Purpose, Depth, risk, consequence, and intended reliance.

Source Lineage Reveals Hidden Dependence

Ten apparently different sources may ultimately depend upon one original source.

For example:

multiple reports,

multiple news articles,

multiple databases,

or multiple AI systems

may all reproduce information derived from the same underlying dataset.

Without lineage governance, these may appear to provide independent confirmation.

VSRS makes the underlying dependence visible.

Primary and Derived Sources

VALIDOS® distinguishes between primary and derived sources.

A **Primary Source** originates the relevant observation, measurement, record, or event representation.

A **Derived Source** obtains its evidentiary content through another source or transformation.

Derived sources are not inherently weak.

They may provide highly valuable:

- analysis,
- aggregation,
- interpretation,
- normalization,
- or contextualization.

But their derivation must remain visible where it materially affects validation reliability.

Capability Before Reputation

Source reputation alone is not enough.

A globally respected institution may be highly capable in one domain and inappropriate for another.

Likewise, a small technical system may provide extremely reliable primary measurements within a narrow operational function.

VSRS therefore asks:

Is the source capable of performing the evidentiary role assigned to it?

This shifts validation away from reputation-based trust toward role-specific reliability.

Competence Where Judgment Matters

Where evidence depends materially upon human or institutional judgment, competence may become important.

Relevant considerations may include:

- expertise,
- qualification,
- experience,
- methodological understanding,
- domain knowledge,
- and demonstrated capability.

VSRS does not create universal professional qualification rules.

It governs whether the competence available is proportionate to the validation role being performed.

Authority Is Not Reliability

VALIDOS® establishes an important distinction:

Authority ≠ Reliability

Authority may create a legitimate right to issue a decision, certification, opinion, or official record.

Reliability concerns whether the source can be sufficiently relied upon for the particular evidentiary role.

The two may overlap.

They are not identical.

Independence Matters

Validation evidence may sometimes require independent sources.

But independence is more complex than asking whether two organizations have different names.

A source may be:

- organizationally independent,
 - financially dependent,
 - methodologically dependent,
 - operationally independent,
-

- informationally dependent,
- analytically independent,
- or decisionally dependent.

VSRS therefore treats independence as multidimensional.

Multiple Sources Do Not Automatically Mean Independent Sources

This distinction is particularly important.

Suppose five reports support the same validation conclusion.

If all five reports rely upon the same original dataset, they do not necessarily represent five independent evidentiary origins.

VALIDOS® therefore distinguishes:

Source Count

from:

Source Independence and:

Source Independence

from:

Source Diversity

This prevents artificial corroboration.

Conflict Does Not Automatically Mean Unreliable

A conflict of interest is a governance condition, not an automatic verdict.

A source may have a financial, organizational, reputational, contractual, competitive, or personal interest and still provide accurate evidence.

But the conflict should be visible.

VSRS therefore asks whether a conflict:

- exists,
 - is material,
 - can influence the evidentiary role,
 - requires additional controls,
 - requires corroboration,
 - limits reliance,
 - or materially affects Source Reliability.
-

Incentives Matter Even Without Formal Conflict

Sources operate within incentive structures.

A source may be encouraged to:

- report favorable outcomes,
- minimize failures,
- emphasize particular metrics,
- omit uncertainty,
- select convenient evidence,
- or frame results strategically.

VSRS allows these incentives to become part of source-reliability assessment where they materially affect validation.

Intermediaries Create Additional Governance Conditions

Evidence often does not travel directly from origin to validator.

It may pass through systems that:

- translate,
- aggregate,
- filter,
- summarize,
- normalize,
- classify,
- anonymize,
- compress,
- or reinterpret it.

Each material intermediary can change the evidentiary pathway.

VSRS therefore governs the source chain rather than assuming that the final provider represents the complete origin.

Transformation Can Change Meaning

Evidence transformation may be legitimate and necessary.

But transformation can also:

- remove detail,
- alter granularity,
- introduce assumptions,
- change statistical properties,
- hide uncertainty,
- or modify interpretation.

VSRS therefore keeps material transformations visible.

The question is not whether transformation occurred.

The question is whether the transformation pathway remains sufficiently governable for validation reliance.

Corroboration Must Be Real

Corroboration can strengthen validation.

But repeated information does not automatically create corroboration.

VALIDOS® establishes:

Repetition ≠ Independent Corroboration

True corroboration requires sufficient independence between the relevant evidentiary origins.

VSRS therefore evaluates whether apparently converging sources possess hidden shared dependencies.

Convergence Can Increase Confidence

Where multiple sufficiently independent sources reach compatible evidentiary outcomes, confidence may increase.

But convergence itself must remain governed.

Several sources may converge because they share:

- the same dataset,
- the same methodology,
- the same upstream information,
- the same bias,
- the same model,
- or the same institutional assumptions.

VSRS therefore asks not only:

Do the sources agree?

but:

Why do the sources agree?

Source Reliability Is Role-Specific

A source should not simply receive a permanent label:

Trusted

or:

Untrusted

A source may be:

Reliable for measurement

Conditionally Reliable for interpretation

and:

Unreliable for conclusions outside its competence

at the same time.

VSRS therefore attaches reliability to the source-role relationship.

Source Reliability Can Be Conditional

A source may be reliable only under defined conditions.

Examples include:

- a calibrated instrument within a specified range,
- an expert within a defined professional domain,
- a database within a defined period,
- a model within a specific version,
- a laboratory under defined procedures,
- or an organization within a specific jurisdiction.

Conditional reliability must remain attached to subsequent validation use.

Source Reliability Can Change

Source reliability is not necessarily permanent.

It may change because of:

- source modification,
- ownership change,
- system compromise,
- expired calibration,
- personnel change,
- newly discovered conflict,
- methodology change,
- altered incentives,
- new upstream dependencies,
- or newly discovered provenance information.

VSRS therefore treats source reliability as a lifecycle condition.

Reliability Can Expire

Some Source Reliability Determinations should have a defined period of applicability.

For example, reliability may depend upon:

- current calibration,
- active certification,
- current competence,
- current independence,
- a specific system version,
- or a particular organizational condition.

Expiration does not automatically mean that the source becomes unreliable.

It means that the previous reliability determination should no longer be assumed current.

Source Reliability Is Not Truth

This boundary is critical.

VALIDOS® establishes:

Reliable Source ≠ True Claim

A highly reliable source can be wrong.

A historically unreliable source can occasionally provide correct information.

VSRS does not transform source reputation into truth.

It governs how much methodological reliance the source relationship can legitimately support within validation.

Source Reliability Is Not Evidence Fitness

Likewise:

Reliable Source ≠ Fit Evidence

A highly reliable source may provide evidence irrelevant to the current validation.

And:

Fit Evidence ≠ Reliable Source

Highly relevant evidence may originate from an uncertain source.

This separation is one of the structural strengths of VALIDOS®.

Source Reliability Is Not Validation

Even:

Fit Evidence + Reliable Source

does not mean:

Validation Object Valid

Those conditions merely establish a stronger evidentiary basis upon which subsequent Validation Execution and Validation Determination can operate.

VALIDOS® therefore prevents premature validity conclusions at every stage.

Position Within VALIDOS®

Validation Source Reliability Standard is the sixth Parent Standard of **VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture**.

Its architectural position is:

**Validation Object → Validation Purpose & Scope → Validation Criteria
→ Validation Method → Validation Evidence Fitness → Validation
Source Reliability → Validation Execution → Validation Determination
→ Validation State → Validation Reliance & Revalidation**

The architecture has now progressed from defining the validation problem to establishing both:

what evidence is fit

and:

whether the sources behind that evidence can be relied upon.

Relationship to Other OOF® Architectures

VSRS operates alongside complementary OOF® architectures.

OBIDENTITY® may establish origin, identity, ownership, provenance, transfer, and continuity relationships.

INTEGROS® may establish integrity conditions affecting sources and evidentiary pathways.

GOA™ may establish governance authority and structural responsibilities.

AGA™ may establish accountability relationships concerning evidence generation, transformation, review, and use.

ORA™ may establish whether source information corresponds to operational reality.

AIG®, CLIA®, MGIA™, and **ASGA™** may create specialized source conditions for AI behavior, cognition, memory, and autonomous systems.

RIS™ may influence the required strength of source assurance according to risk and consequence.

VSRS does not duplicate these architectures.

It consumes relevant governed information and answers a narrower validation-specific question:

What does this information mean for the reliability of this source in this validation role?

Why It Matters

Modern validation increasingly depends upon complex evidence chains.

An AI validation may involve:

Sensor → Dataset → Data Processor → Model → Analytical Tool → Human Evaluator → Validation Record

A scientific validation may involve:

Experiment → Instrument → Researcher → Statistical Processing → Publication → Secondary Analysis

An operational validation may involve:

Event → System Log → Aggregator → Dashboard → Analyst → Validation Decision

At every transition, source relationships matter.

VSRS provides a methodology for making those relationships visible and governable.

From Source Trust to Source Governance

Traditional validation may ask:

Do we trust this source?

VALIDOS® replaces this with a stronger set of questions:

Who or what is the source?

What role does it perform?

Where did its information originate?

What transformations occurred?

Is it capable of performing this role?

Is it independent where independence matters?

What dependencies exist?

What conflicts or incentives exist?

What are the boundaries of its reliability?

Can the source relationship be reconstructed?

This transforms source trust from an intuitive judgment into a governable methodological structure.

Foundational Principle

Evidence cannot become more trustworthy merely because its source remains unquestioned.

Canonical Closing Statement

Validation Source Reliability Standard establishes the source-qualification layer of VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture. By separating source reliability from evidence fitness, truth, authority, and final validity, and by governing source identity, attribution, provenance, lineage, capability, competence, independence, dependence, conflicts, incentives, intermediaries, transformations, corroboration, convergence, limitations, uncertainty, change, expiration, and traceability, VSRS transforms source trust from an assumption into a governable validation condition.

Parent Resources

[→ VALIDOS® Architecture Map](#)

[→ VALIDOS® Complete Standards & Modules Index](#)

Related Documents

[→ Validation Source Reliability Standard](#)

[→ VALIDOS® Validation Governance Architecture — Validation Governance Layer](#)

OOF® MIP® Protection Notice

OOF® · Protected under MIP® — Methodological Intellectual Property

Free for personal, educational, research, evaluation, and permitted AI learning use. Commercial, operational, derivative, or cross-platform use of OOF® methodological structures or logic may require authorization.

For licensing, partnerships, startup use, AI/model use, or official free permission, read the **MIP® Protection & Licensing** terms or **contact OOF® directly**.

Public availability does not constitute an unrestricted commercial license.

Active Protection & Compatibility Detection applies.

Canonical Source

<https://originopenfoundation.org/>